

How long have you been dancing the Lindy Hop? Please describe your Lindy Hop community experience.

I started dancing Lindy Hop in 2011 in Cambridge, UK, with the Cambridge Swing Dance society. From 2011 to 2016, I was very active in the swing dance community. I trained regularly (2-3 times a week), helped organise the Cambridge Lindy Exchange as part of the committee, taught beginner classes, and attended workshops with international teachers such as Kevin & Jo, Peter and Naomi, Frida & Skye. I also travelled to social dance in different cities across the UK, Europe, Japan, and China. As a migrant in the UK, Lindy Hop community gave me so many life-long friendships, joy and laughter that I had never experienced before and it transformed me from a shy introvert person to someone taking the stage as a DJ, public speaking while teaching classes and holding conversation with strangers from across the world.

In 2016, I injured my ankle and had to stop dancing. In 2018, I returned to India to focus on treatment and recovery. Over the next six years, I saw nine doctors and several physiotherapists before finally getting medical clearance to dance again in 2024.

In 2024, I also lost my father and grandmother in the same year. That period made me reflect deeply on what brings me joy and meaning. Lindy Hop had shaped my life in my twenties, and coming back to it in my thirties felt healing and grounding.

When I looked for a Lindy Hop community in Delhi, I realised there wasn't an active scene. That is what led me to start building one. I founded Swing Out Delhi to create the kind of joyful, welcoming community that once changed my own life.

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11. Briefly describe what you would like to learn in each of the following areas:

a. Lindy Hop social dancing b. Lindy Hop history and cultural values c. Lindy Hop performance

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a. Lindy Hop social dancing

I would like to deepen my social dancing skills with a focus on musicality, connection, rhythm variation, and improvisation. After several years away from dancing due to injury, I want to refine my technique and rebuild my physical vocabulary. Stronger social dancing will directly impact how I teach and model movement for my community.

b. Lindy Hop history and cultural values

Because I am building a new scene in India, I feel a strong responsibility to teach Lindy Hop with proper historical context and cultural respect. Currently, I rely heavily on books and online resources. I want to deepen my understanding of the African American roots of the dance, the legacy of the Savoy Ballroom, and Frankie Manning's philosophy of joy, inclusivity, and community. This knowledge will help me build a scene that honors its origins.

c. Lindy Hop performance

This will be a long term goal for our community in Delhi, to have a troupe of dancers. I would like to better understand performance structure and choreography, — not for competitive purposes, but to use performance as a way to introduce Lindy Hop to wider audiences in India. This would help create visibility for the scene. I've never performed so I don't have that experience yet.

12. What have you done so far to introduce Lindy Hop or build the Lindy Hop scene in a leadership role?

In April 2025, a Swedish dancer, Björn, was visiting Delhi. We connected through Instagram, met in person, and I suggested we teach a few trial classes together. Those first classes became the beginning of *SwingOut Delhi*.

Since launching on 27 April 2025, I have taken on a full leadership role in building the scene from the ground up in a city where Lindy Hop previously did not exist.

In our first year, I have:

- Launched multiple beginner courses and regular class blocks on foundational Lindy Hop and Charleston
- Introduced over **250 dancers** to Lindy Hop
- Reached out to three independent music venues to host socials — Depot 48 took a chance on us and became an early supporter. Organized **9 social dances** (our first social was on 5 August 2025)
- DJed social dancing nights to build musical familiarity in the community
- Organized swing jazz evenings with visiting bands, including taking our dancers to hear a visiting swing jazz band perform live — for many, it was their first experience dancing to live swing music
- Hosted free community practice sessions funded through internal class revenue, offering two-hour guided practice spaces
- Conducted introductory workshops for three different groups: a Development Sector network, the Oxford & Cambridge Society of India alumni, and a private corporate event — which led to new dancers joining regular classes
- Encouraged international exchange — four of our dancers are traveling to Thailand Swing Era in August 2026 for the first time.

- Welcomed visiting dancers from Venezuela, Goa, France, Mumbai, the UK, and the US
- Built an Instagram page to share information (<https://www.instagram.com/swingoutdelhi/>)

I currently manage teaching, operations, programming, DJing, partnerships, and community engagement. Whenever experienced dancers or teachers visit Delhi, I invite them to co-teach. I have also mentored some beginners to assist in classes, beginning to build a teaching team.

Culturally, I am building the scene in an Indian context. Community in India is deeply tied to food, festivals, and shared celebration. I offer free snacks and beverages during block classes to encourage bonding, and we organize festival-themed socials — including our first Holi Swing Social in March 2026. I have intentionally kept pricing accessible compared to other partner dance scenes, being mindful of economic and social barriers that often limit participation.

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13. Our goal with the Frankie Manning Scholarship is to grow strong, vested leaders with a commitment to sharing and continuing the legacy of Frankie Manning. We are looking for dancers who want to take on leadership roles spreading the Lindy Hop in the African American community or who seek to introduce it to a place in the world where Lindy Hop is relatively new. These leadership roles can come in the form of hosting your own events, performance, dance instruction, choreography, creating/building community dance scenes, volunteering at schools or senior centers, or using your skill set by volunteering with Lindy Hop organizations, through outreach to other dance forms, etc. What are your long-term plans for building or contributing to the Lindy Hop community? Where would you like to build Lindy hop?

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My long-term goal is to build and sustain a vibrant Lindy Hop scene in Delhi and surrounding areas. I would like to:

- Develop a strong team of local teachers and volunteers on a community-model
- Host visiting international instructors
- Encourage dancers to travel and connect globally
- Organize jazz history movie nights and educational discussions
- Build inclusive spaces (especially welcoming mothers and working professionals)
- Eventually host larger festivals or exchanges in Delhi

I also want to incorporate spirituality and gratitude into my teaching Lindy Hop, as someone who recovered from an ankle injury and personal losses, dancing and its capability to heal is very meaningful to me.

I have experienced the UK swing dance scene the most and would like to build that kind of volunteer-led community platform. India has a rich culture of music and rhythm, but Lindy

Hop is still relatively new here. I would like to position Swing Out Delhi on the global Lindy Hop map while staying rooted in the dance's African American origins and values of joy, generosity, and community.

14. Please describe your financial situation. How would this scholarship help you to achieve your goals?

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As the founder of a new dance community in a developing scene, resources are limited. Swing Out Delhi is still in its early stages, and much of the work is self-funded and community-supported. Traveling internationally for training requires significant financial commitment, especially from India. This scholarship would reduce that barrier and allow me to access high-quality instruction and community immersion that would otherwise be difficult.

The impact would not be individual — it would ripple outward. Every improvement in my dancing, teaching, and historical understanding would directly benefit the 100+ dancers in our growing community.

This scholarship would help me grow as a leader so that I can continue to grow Lindy Hop in a place where it is still new and full of potential.